Chemotherapy for stomach cancer

Chemotherapy uses anti-cancer (cytotoxic) drugs to destroy cancer cells. For stomach cancer it may be used on its own, or with surgery, radiotherapy or a targeted therapy drug.

On this page

- What is chemotherapy?
- When chemotherapy is used for stomach cancer
- Chemotherapy drugs used for treating stomach cancer
- How chemotherapy is given
- How we can help

What is chemotherapy?

Chemotherapy uses anti-cancer (cytotoxic) drugs to destroy cancer cells. It may be used on its own, or with surgery, radiotherapy or a targeted therapy drug.

When chemotherapy is used for stomach cancer

Chemotherapy for stomach cancer may be given:

- both before and after surgery (perioperative chemotherapy)
- after surgery (adjuvant chemotherapy)
- with radiotherapy (chemoradiation)
- on its own or with immunotherapy or targeted therapy (palliative treatment).

Perioperative chemotherapy

When chemotherapy is used both before and after surgery, it is called perioperative chemotherapy. This treatment shrinks the tumour to make surgery more effective. This reduces the chance of the cancer coming back. You usually have chemotherapy for 2 to 3 months before the operation, and again for 2 to 3 months after it.

Adjuvant chemotherapy

When chemotherapy is used after surgery, it is called adjuvant chemotherapy. Adjuvant chemotherapy may be given to reduce the risk of the cancer coming back.

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/chemotherapy-for-stomach-cancer · retrieved 19 October 2026

Palliative chemotherapy

Chemotherapy can be used as the main treatment:

- if the cancer cannot be removed by surgery
- to control cancer that has spread to other parts of the body (advanced cancer).

You may have more than 1 course of chemotherapy. It can help control the cancer and reduce symptoms. Some people have a targeted therapy drug called trastuzumab or an immunotherapy drug called nivolumab as well as chemotherapy. You will have tests first to find out if trastuzumab or nivolumab is a suitable treatment for you.

Chemotherapy drugs used for treating stomach cancer

Usually, a combination of drugs is used to treat stomach cancer. The chemotherapy drugs most commonly used are:

- fluorouracil (5FU) or capecitabine
- cisplatin
- docetaxel
- oxaliplatin.

Other drugs that may be used are:

- capecitabine
- irinotecan
- paclitaxel

Treatments are sometimes named after the initials of the drugs included. One example is FLOT, which uses:

- fluorouracil (5FU)
- folinic acid (leucovorin)
- oxaliplatin
- docetaxel (Taxotere®).

How chemotherapy is given

You usually have chemotherapy treatment in a chemotherapy day unit. This means you can go home on the same day.

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/chemotherapy-for-stomach-cancer · retrieved 19 October 2026

After each session, you usually have a rest period of a few weeks. This allows your body to recover from the side effects. The treatment and the rest period make up a cycle of treatment. Your specialist will talk to you about this and tell you how many cycles you are likely to have.

You have the chemotherapy drugs given into a vein (intravenously) or as tablets. Stomach cancer is sometimes treated with a combination of both.

We have more information about how chemotherapy is given.

Booklets and resources

Booklets

01 Mar 2022

Understanding chemotherapy

Booklets

01 Mar 2022

Chemotherapy - easy read

Audiobooks

01 Mar 2022

Understanding chemotherapy

About our information

This information has been written, revised and edited by Macmillan Cancer Support's Cancer Information Development team. It has been reviewed by expert medical and health professionals and people living with cancer.

References

Below is a sample of the sources used in our stomach cancer information. If you would like more information about the sources we use, please contact us at informationproductionteam@macmillan.org.uk

Lordick F, Carneiro S, Cascinu T, Fleitas K, Haustermans G, Piessen A, et al. Gastric cancer: ESMO Clinical Practice Guideline for diagnosis, treatment and follow-up. Annals of Oncology. 2022;33(10): 1005–1020. Available from www.doi.org/10.1016/j.annonc.2022.07.004 [accessed July 2023].

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/chemotherapy-for-stomach-cancer · retrieved 19 October 2026

National Institute for Care and Health Excellence. Oesophago-gastric cancer: assessment and management in adults NICE guideline [NG83]. 2018. Available from www.nice.org.uk/guidance/ng83 [accessed July 2023].

Cancer Information Development team

Author

Dr Chris Jones

Reviewer

Speciality Registrar in Clinical Oncologist and Clinical Lecturer in Clinical Oncology

Date reviewed

Reviewed: 01 November 2024 | Next review: 01 November 2027

Our cancer information meets the PIF TICK quality mark.

This means it is easy to use, up-to-date and based on the latest evidence. Learn more about how we produce our information.

The language we use

We want everyone affected by cancer to feel our information is written for them.

We want our information to be as clear as possible. To do this, we try to:

- use plain English
- explain medical words
- use short sentences
- use illustrations to explain text
- structure the information clearly
- make sure important points are clear.

We use gender-inclusive language and talk to our readers as ‘you’ so that everyone feels included. Where clinically necessary we use the terms ‘men’ and ‘women’ or ‘male’ and ‘female’. For example, we do so when talking about parts of the body or mentioning statistics or research about who is affected.

You can read more about how we produce our information here.

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/chemotherapy-for-stomach-cancer · retrieved 19 October 2026

How we can help

Macmillan Support Line

The Macmillan Support Line is a free and confidential service for people living with and affected by cancer. If you need to talk, we'll listen.

Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.

Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don’t want to call.

Online Community

Chat online anonymously to others who understand what you are going through. Our community is available 24/7 and has dedicated forums where you can get advice and ask our experts.

Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.

Get help

© Macmillan Cancer Support. Reproduced with permission. Source: https://www.macmillan.org.uk/cancer-information-and-support/treatments-and-drugs/chemotherapy-for-stomach-cancer · retrieved 19 October 2026